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Turnout low for tax-raising proposals

1 in 5 voters decided outcome of recent costly measures, Cook County treasurer's office says

By A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Despite Cook County residents' long, loud complaints about out-of-control property taxes and government spending, a majority of them couldn't be bothered to turn

out to vote in recent elections when given the chance to decide whether taxes should be hiked.

About 1 in 5 eligible voters decided the outcome of costly binding property tax questions in various suburbs in the past couple of years, according to a new study from

the Cook County treasurer's office.

Across the consolidated and primary elections in April 2025 and March 2026, they said yes to a total of \$335.5 million in bonds or new debt and \$3.7 million in new taxes, while turning down another \$54 million in bonds and \$3.5 million in taxes, the study found.

It's the third "the few decide for the many" report from Maria Pappas' office drawing attention

to low turnout and drop-off in elections where voters have a say in whether local property taxes should go up to pay for roads, new buildings, emergency equipment or renovations.

Of the 20 referendums on various suburban ballots in the consolidated election in 2025 and the 2026 primary, 15 passed.

In four south suburban townships, advisory referendums asked

voters if they wanted tax rebates. Those "were overwhelmingly approved — a symbolic expression of frustration with high tax rates in the region," the report said. But those, too, saw an average turnout of only 21.5%.

While sometimes hotly debated, like the recent Chicago City Council fight over a trio of questions for next

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2 mosques burn in West Bank violence

Palestinians accuse Israeli government of ignoring settler attacks

By Melanie Lidman
ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEL AVIV, Israel — Two mosques in the Israeli-occupied West Bank were set on fire overnight in an apparent Israeli settler attack, officials said Sunday, after a spate of deadly violence that killed four Palestinians and two Israeli soldiers.

Palestinians and the Israeli opposition accuse Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's hard-line government of turning a blind eye to attacks by settlers against Palestinians, which threatens to ignite widespread violence across the territory.

Israeli soldiers and police fanned out across the West Bank after the attack, closing off major roads and blocking access to a hospital where it said two militants were hiding. Israel also arrested more than 70 Palestinians over the weekend as they attempted to contain the escalating violence.

The mosques, in the villages of Qusra and Kour in the northern West Bank, suffered extensive damage in the fires. In Qusra, the attackers spray-painted "revenge Benayahu," referring to one of the Israeli soldiers killed on Friday, and "the land of Israel is redeemed with blood." The soldier lived in a nearby settlement.

Ahmed Abu Mahmoud, who lives next to the Qusra mosque, said he heard noises at 3 a.m. and discovered the mosque had been set on fire. The fire was too large for him to fight on his own, so he called for help.

"The military arrived here, saw with their own eyes and then left," Mahmoud said.

Security footage in Kour obtained by The Associated Press showed three people dressed in civilian clothes setting off a large explosion in the entrance of the mosque in the middle of the night.

On Sunday, residents held prayers despite damage to the entrance.

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ICE is holding their mother, despite her green card

By Allison Kiehl | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Beata Siemionkowicz spent her first night in Kentucky's Campbell County Detention Center in a cell with black mold covering the air vents and dead bedbugs lingering in the room's corners. There was blood smeared above the doorway.

Siemionkowicz shared that pod with 60 other women, many of whom, like herself, were immigrants in the United States detained by Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents.

The Poland native, a green card holder of more than two decades, was arrested days earlier in Des Plaines. Her first night in Campbell County was Aug. 4, 2025. She has remained incarcerated in northern Kentucky since, for the last 51 weeks.

Now, nearly one year later, Siemionkowicz's family continues to fight for her freedom. Her former cellmate, whom she spent that first night with in Kentucky, may be the legal case study that will get

An Illinois woman has been kept in a Kentucky detention center for almost a year as her daughters plead for her release

Above: Sisters Claudia, left, and Gabi Siemionkowicz stand in Claudia's Des Plaines backyard, where their mother, Beata Siemionkowicz, was detained by ICE while gardening last August.
BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

her out of ICE custody, her friends and family hope.

"Beata did all the paperwork right; she even applied for naturalization," said Donna Hughes-Brown, an Irish citizen who was incarcerated with Siemionkowicz and described the conditions they endured. Hughes-Brown has since been released; the deportation charges in her case were unfounded.

"She had done everything right," Hughes-Brown said about Siemionkowicz. "And it didn't matter."

Siemionkowicz could not be reached for comment in detention. But her family says and records show that she entered the United States legally in 1995, moving to Illinois from her hometown of Bialystok, Poland. She has been a permanent resident with a green card since 2003.

A divorced, single mom of two, Siemionkowicz built her life in Round Lake as

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INSIDE

'Exploring Music' host remembered

Bill McGlaughlin, the musician and founding host of the syndicated WFMT show, was praised for his approachable style in guiding listeners through classical music. He died Tuesday. **Arts & Living**

Murakami hits career high

White Sox manager Will Venable wished for Munetaka Murakami to have a great game on the day of his bobblehead promotion, and he did, collecting 6 RBIs in a 12-3 victory against the Astros. **Sports**

Latino officers to be largest racial group in CPD

Demographic shift appears to mirror Chicago's population

By Sam Charles
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In the coming months, for the first time in the 191-year history of the Chicago Police Department, white officers will no longer be the largest racial group in the department's rank-and-file.

Data from the city's Office of Inspector General shows that likely before the end of 2026, Latino officers will overtake white officers as the plurality in the department.

For many, the literal changing face of the department will

take it further from the ingrained imagery of its past, when the sons of immigrants from Ireland and other points in Europe may have been the first to come to mind. In short, this is not Richard J. Daley's CPD.

The shift in the department's workforce largely mirrors the shifting demographics of the city overall, according to Dick Simpson, professor emeritus at the University of Illinois Chicago and a former Chicago alderman.

"Since the city's founding back in the 1830s, as soon as they had a police force in the decades that followed, there was always a majority — and usually a very strong majority — of white police

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Chicago police officers Francis Martillo and Detinee Reib embrace after their graduation ceremony on Wednesday at Navy Pier. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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